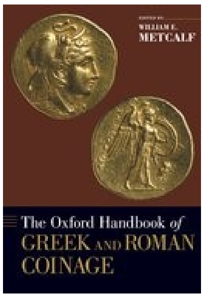

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CHAPTER

13 The Seleucids

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Abstract

Early Seleucid monetary policy evolved unevenly as the Seleucid state, where the use of coined money was a relatively recent introduction, focused its efforts on military requirements, city building, and public works. From its earliest years, Seleucid monetary authorities in both eastern and western regions of the kingdom maintained an open financial system in which all currencies were the same. The system allowed the Seleucid state to use standard tetradrachms of any origin for internal payments, including tax revenue payments or payments by Seleucid authorities for military purposes. In time, as Seleucid territorial expansion slowed and state administrative behavior became more regularized, a greater degree of systematization and regularity in monetary decision making came into effect. The second century witnessed a number of changes in Seleucid mint administration, such as the use and placement of symbols and controls, and the expansion and later extinction of dated coinage in northern Syria.

Keywords: Seleucid, monetary policy, currencies, systematization, dated coinage

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EARLY Seleucid monetary policy evolved unevenly as the Seleucid state, originally centered in non-Greek lands where the use of coined money was a relatively recent introduction, focused its efforts on military requirements, city building, and public works. In time, as Seleucid territorial expansion slowed and state administrative behavior became more regularized, a greater degree of systematization and regularity in monetary decision-making came into effect. Nevertheless, an overview of Seleucid monetary policy and production shows a continuing interest in experimentation and change, region to region and even city to city. The state's early responses to questions of whether to issue coins, where, in what volume, with what denominations, and with what message content were addressed variably from the beginning. As the overall pattern of production and circulation strongly suggests, however, the Seleucid kingdom was only partly monetized over the course of its existence.

Seleucid Mints and Money Production

Gold and Silver

The earliest cities to strike the first Seleucid coins were in the east, where Seleucus I (312–281) had established himself in 311 B.C. after gaining Ptolemy's support for his return to Babylonia. Babylon, which had struck extensively for Alexander and Antigonus after Alexander's death, was Seleucus's earliest and most voluminous mint, issuing gold and silver coinage of differing types and standards, including p. 236 ↳ Alexander's imperial Attic weight money (fig. 13.1) and Persic standard gold and silver (fig. 13.2) that circulated regionally (*SC1*: 50–51; *SC2*: 701–714). The more distant eastern mints of Susa and Ecbatana followed suit, albeit in less volume. Apart from these three large facilities and two others at Ai Khanoum (or Bactra), and Alexandria Area, the early coinages of other eastern areas were relatively insignificant.

Fig. 13.1

Fig. 13.2

Fig. 13.3

The mint of Seleucia on the Tigris, which had replaced Babylon as the locus of the Seleucid court at the end of the fourth century, as well as Susa and Ecbatana, energetically produced Seleucid silver money until the collapse of Seleucid authority in the late second century. Of the two mints, Seleucia was both the most active and the longest lasting, striking tetradrachms, occasional drachms, and bronze coinage through the second century until the city's seizure in 141 by the Parthian ruler Mithradates I, then briefly under Antiochus VII (138–129) during his reoccupation of the city in 130–129 (fig. 13.3). Susa produced tetradrachms until its capture by the native dynast Kamnaskires I in 145, and a small coinage for Demetrius II (Second Reign, 129–125) when he temporarily recovered the city, while Ecbatana issued tetradrachms (and under Demetrius I many drachms) for Alexander I (152–145) before the city fell to Mithradates in 148 or 147.

Elsewhere in the east, Nisibis, which had been a highly active silver mint during the early reign of Antiochus III and another large mint in the same area that operated somewhat later (Uncertain Mint 68: *SC1*: 429–432) shut down after his death. Seleucus IV opened several transient silver mints in Media and Mesopotamia, as well as one at Antioch in Persis that struck tetradrachms through the reign of Antiochus IV (*SC2* nos. 1526–1528). An important silver mint (first identified by Mørkholm 1970) was opened by Antiochus IV at an uncertain location on the Persian Gulf and continued in operation through the first reign of Demetrius II (146–138; *SC*2: 110–111).

p. 237 In the west, territorial acquisitions in the last years of the fourth and early third centuries extended Seleucid sovereignty over regions with much longer traditions of coinage—Cilicia, western Asia Minor, and Syria, where large volumes of silver currency issued from non-Seleucid mints circulated broadly. Throughout the third century, lifetime and posthumous Alexanders, along with Lysimachi and Attalid tetradrachms, appear to have been sufficient to the needs of the Seleucid state and commerce, and there was little incentive for the Seleucid financial authorities to augment the supply of new silver money. Le Rider (1986) provides the extensive hoard evidence for the broad circulation of mixed "international" silver currencies in the period.

The most important mint facilities at Laodicea ad Mare, followed by Sardes and Antioch, issued tetradrachms episodically in low volumes, while an array of occasional mints sprang up, striking what appear to have been small-volume issues of prestige or emissions of amity between the king and a subject city.

Important changes occurred after the middle of the third century. Gold stater production for regular use—never very large in any circumstance—appears to have ended around 240 B.C., or perhaps a little later, under Seleucus II (246–226). The view that circulating gold ended early in Seleucus's reign under Seleucus II is based on the very low rate of recovery of staters of any later period. Certain Seleucid rulers, including Seleucus III in the 3rd century B.C., are not known to have issued gold coinage at all.

Gold produced from then on by later rulers, including a number of spectacular octodrachm issues, seems to have been struck only for honorific and emergency purposes (figs. 13.4, 13.5). At the same time, Seleucid silver

p. 238 production began to increase gradually. Antioch, which theretofore had struck tetradrachms in very ↳ limited volume, generally using an average of less than two obverse dies per year, significantly expanded production during the early and mid-second century, employing 5 to 10 dies per year under Antiochus IV (175–164 B.C.) and, with some exceptions (production was not always stable from year to year), between 10 and 20 under Demetrius I (162–150 B.C.) through the second reign of Demetrius II (at Antioch, 129–8 B.C.; Le Rider 1999; Hoover and Iossif forthcoming). In addition to tetradrachms, the Antioch mint began to strike increasing numbers of drachms, and from the reign of Antiochus IV also issued occasional fractions. Tetradrachm emissions from Seleucia on the Calycadnus, Soli and Tarsus in Cilicia, Damascus (under Antiochus III and Seleucus IV), Ptolemaïs (Ake), and a number of smaller mints added to the region's money supply.

Fig. 13.4

Fig. 13.5

Fig. 13.6

At midcentury, under Alexander I (152–145 B.C.) the Phoenician cities of Berytus, Sidon, Tyre, and Ptolemaïs (Ake) began to issue silver with eagle reverses on the lightweight standard of around 14-plus grams (fig. 13.6). Tyre produced by far the largest volume of silver coin, including tetradrachms, didrachms, and some drachms, through the second reign of Demetrius II, until 125, when the city was granted autonomous status (see Iossif forthcoming). Despite the advantage the new coinage represented to the region's financial authorities by being keyed to the Ptolemaic system that ensured consistency with silver money then circulating in Phoenicia and Coele Syria, it was unusable elsewhere in the kingdom, where Attic-standard silver appeared exclusively. Only after 125, when Tyre was granted autonomy and began to produce its own silver coinage, did southern mints such as Sidon and Ptolemaïs (Ake) recommence the issuance of Attic standard tetradrachms that could be used in other areas of the Seleucid state (*SC*2: 2329–2330, Sidon; 2335–2336, Ptolemaïs). Perhaps in response to territorial changes in the east, the Damascus mint reopened in 137, striking silver in volume for Antiochus VII and later much bronze, continuing as an important Seleucid mint until the city's seizure by Aretas III sometime after 84 B.C.

Bronze

From very modest beginnings, the supply of bronze coinage in the Seleucid kingdom grew as the role of bronze became broadly and increasingly important to the economies of the Hellenistic states. A significant expansion of bronze production occurred in the early third century in the western Seleucid territories. Two western mints in particular, Sardes and Antioch on the Orontes, produced bronze coins in particular abundance, and in time, bronze production was expanded among the major eastern mints as well. Across the kingdom, various lesser mints issued bronze exclusively, on a small scale and for a limited period, and were probably called into being p. 239 by special local circumstances. Occasional bronze coinages with military types ↳ (horses, elephants) seem to indicate production by or for the Seleucid army (fig. 13.7), and late in the century, under Antiochus III (223–187), bronze production was undertaken by the army for use during the king's campaigns in Coele Syria during the Fifth Syrian War (*SC1:* 409–418; fig. 13.8).

Fig. 13.7

Fig. 13.8

By the end of the third century, the production of Seleucid bronze coinage in Asia Minor had virtually ceased. Antioch, however, began to produce an increasingly large volume of bronze money for Antiochus III, including small denomination coins that in time evolved into a regional currency. In time, the Antioch mint became the principal supplier of bronze money to Syria and other areas of the Seleucid north, issuing large quantities of coin under Seleucus IV, Antiochus IV, and their successors through the second century and into the first, ceasing production around 93 B.C. under Antiochus XI before establishing an entirely civic coinage of its own.

Elsewhere in the west, Ptolemaïs (Ake) and Damascus became major suppliers of bronze to Coele Syria and southern Phoenicia, respectively, albeit in different periods (Ptolemaïs from Antiochus III through the joint reign of Cleopatra and Antiochus VIII, 125–121 B.C.; Damascus beginning with Antiochus VII but especially under Demetrius III and Antiochus XII, 97/96–84/83 B.C.). In Phoenicia, the Tyre mint produced bronze coins for regional use under Antiochus III and his immediate successors and began under Demetrius I to issue larger volumes of bronze money, continuing to do so until 125; Byblus, Berytus, and Sidon became moderately active bronze facilities, albeit for shorter periods. In the east, Seleucia on the Tigris, Susa, and Ecbatana were all active bronze mints until the collapse of Seleucid authority. Of these, Seleucia was the most prolific, issuing bronzes in varied denominations and types into the brief reign of Antiochus VII.

p. 240 Unlike silver money, which was, from the end of the third century, continuously replaced throughout the areas of Seleucid rule, bronze coins could remain in use for very long periods, often more than a hundred years after they were struck (as Bijovsky 2001–2002 has shown). Bronze coins of often widely varying weight and size, civic issues as well as Seleucid, circulated at the same time, and while it is not entirely clear how they were valued against each other, it seems probable that their value was determined on the basis of approximate size, as well as type where type-differentiated currencies remained in circulation.

Tetradrachm Circulation and the Two-Tiered Monetary System

From its earliest years, Seleucid monetary authorities in both eastern and western regions of the kingdom maintained an open financial system in which all currencies on the same Attic standard could circulate freely, both internally and across its frontiers. The system allowed the Seleucid state to use standard tetradrachms of any origin for internal payments, including tax revenue payments or payments by Seleucid authorities for military purposes (personnel pay, victualing, transport, etc.). It also permitted simplicity of exchange across state boundaries for official or commercial purposes. Even after the loss of Seleucid possessions in Asia Minor to Rome in 189 B.C., the system was generally continued in the northern and eastern areas of Seleucid authority—principally Cilicia, Mesopotamia, and Babylonia. With the exception of Phoenicia, where, as has been noted, Seleucid coins were struck on the lighter Ptolemaic standard, the open Attic system was maintained long into the second century until it collapsed in the century's last quarter (see below).

Precious high-value silver money had certain limitations. For local, everyday use, low-value, often overvalued bronze coins remained the currency of choice. The result was the continuation of a two-tier system of coinages of vastly disproportionate values. Where it circulated in quantity, overvalued bronze may have helped bridge the gap between the two tiers, but irregular bronze production must have left large areas of the Seleucid state without an intermediate currency or means to convert silver coin to daily use.

Later Seleucid Money and Messages

Early Seleucid money carried visual messages intended to support the primacy and power of the Seleucid dynasty or the specific mythology of the reigning monarch. Coin types alluded to the mythological origins and associations of the p. 241 ↳ Seleucids (Heracles, Zeus, Apollo, or Athena; fig. 13.9); their victories (Nike, trophies; fig. 13.10) and military might (elephants and, more exceptionally, arms; fig. 13.11); their occasional associations with Alexander the Great (relatively rare portraits of the ruler, at times in elephant headdress as Alexander, conqueror of the east; fig. 13.12); their divinity (Seleucus I as Dionysus; Antiochus III as Apollo or with horns; fig. 13.13); and their relations with communities (civic badges; fig. 13.14; Hoover 2004).

Fig. 13.9

Fig. 13.10

Fig. 13.11

Fig. 13.12

Fig. 13.13

Fig. 13.14

Antiochus IV expanded the repertoire of messages carried on coins. To his own portrait, he added a radiate crown at Antioch and other cities and made images of Zeus a major feature of his silver and bronze (the radiate p. 242 portrait, suggesting an assimilation with Helios or some local celestial divinities, reappeared on coins of ↳

later rulers, through Antiochus XII; fig. 13.15). (For the Helios motif see Iossif and Lorber 2009b.) In addition to the usual, “of King Antiochus,” he added epithets attesting to his divine authority: “Theos” (“God”) on silver of Ecbatana; “Theos Epiphanes” (“God Manifest”) on silver and bronze of Antioch and bronzes of certain other mints; and “Theos Epiphanes Nicephorus” (the latter: “Bringer” or “Bearer of Victory”) on tetradrachms of Antioch and Ptolemaïs. All Antiochus's successors continued the practice of adding epithets to their coins at one mint or another, generally in the west: the eastern mints, Susa and Ecbatana in particular, tended to retain the traditional simple royal inscriptions that had prevailed kingdom-wide through the reign of Seleucus IV (although Ecbatana, like many other mints, added “Soter”—“Savior”—to the silver coins of Demetrius I). Likewise, epithets are generally absent from the Phoenician weight silver and bronze coinages of the Phoenician cities. An exceptional stater of Antiochus VII calls the ruler “Megas”—“great”—which appears on several inscriptions that refer to the king but on no other Seleucid issue (*SC2*: 2134).

Several late Seleucid coinages were strenuous in their attempts to proclaim the ruler's virtues, as for example, “Mother-Loving Benefactor, Nobly Victorious” (fig. 13.16) or “Illustrious (or Dionysus Manifest), Father-Loving, of the Noble Victory” (Damascene bronzes of Antiochus XII; Demetrius III: *SC*2: 2447; Antiochus XII: *SC*2, 2482).

Certain motifs that were prevalent on early Seleucid coinages dwindled or disappeared from later ones, while others appeared in new forms. Elephants or elephant heads that prominently appeared on coins of early Seleucid rulers and that may represent the Seleucid army became increasingly rare in the later period, although images of trophies and, quite unusually, arms, were placed on bronze coins into the middle of the second century. Images of Nike and Zeus Nicephorus, attesting to the victorious nature of the ruler and reflecting the military campaigns of the period, abound. Seleucid usurpers, too, placed their personal types on their coins—Timarchus displayed the Dioscuri on his tetradrachm reverses (fig. 13.17), while Tryphon put his own military
p. 243 symbol, a Macedonian helmet, on both silver and bronze of Antioch (fig. 13.18). ↳

Fig. 13.15

Fig. 13.16

Fig. 13.17

Fig. 13.18

IV. Seleucid Mint Administration in the Later Period

The second century witnessed a number of changes in Seleucid mint administration. Some, such as the use and placement of symbols and controls, were evolutionary; others, such as the expansion and later extinction of dated coinage in northern Syria, were episodic. While central control over mint activities during certain reigns and in certain regions is evident, cities were often allowed considerable leeway in establishing their own coinage types, symbols, controls, dates, and conventions. Profound differences between the western and eastern coinages of the Seleucid kingdom persisted throughout.

Mint Symbols, Mintmarks, and Controls

Later Seleucid mints remained substantially disparate in their use of symbols. The large mints of Antioch and Seleucia on the Tigris, for example, continued to follow their earlier practice of applying symbols to their silver only rarely, while Ecbatana continued to display a horse or horse's head on much of its bronze and silver coinage through the reign of Demetrius I. The mints of Cilicia more or less regularly added symbols to represent mint cities on their coins or—as at Seleucia on the Calycadnus, Soli (fig. 13.19), and Mallus (fig. 13.20)—established reverse types that clearly identified the issuing mint. The relatively brief silver coinages of Seleucid Phoenicia, for their part, are distinguished by the appearance of symbols beneath their reverse eagle's
p. 244 feet, sometimes also under its wing or in the left field (as at Tyre) to represent their ↳ issuing locations. Abbreviated ethnics were applied irregularly, except in Phoenicia and parts of Coele Syria, where they appear on virtually all Seleucid silver from Alexander I to Antiochus VII, as well as on much bronze coinage of the issuing cities.

Fig. 13.19

Fig. 13.20

The application of letters and monograms of the same general type that appeared on Seleucid coinage of the third century continued to the end of the dynasty. Most of these likely represented individuals with mint functions, and it is possible to recognize through such marks patterns of mint association, much as is the case with certain coinages of earlier periods. Examples of association can be found between Damascus and Ptolemaïs (Ake) under Seleucus IV, between Antioch and Ptolemaïs under Antiochus IV, and among various north Syrian mints of Antiochus VII that appear to have been under the supervision of a single person at

Antioch. That controls do not always represent individuals is suggested by certain enduring marks with exceptionally long lifetimes that may represent a family or institution. Tyrian monograms with an exceptionally long life in both the royal and the autonomous period may also have represented families or institutions, or perhaps groups (guilds?) of local elites.

Dates

The practice of affixing dates on coins, prevalent in Ptolemaic Phoenicia and Coele Syria, was adopted by Antiochus III on his seizure of these territories in 198, when the mint of Tyre began issuing bronzes showing the Seleucid year. The convention rapidly spread to almost all the mints of Phoenicia and southern Coele Syria and in time was taken up in the Syrian north, including at the mint of Antioch, which began in 155/154 to strike
p. 245 dated tetradrachms for Demetrius I (fig. 13.21), continuing this practice, with ↳ drachm emissions as well, under Alexander I, Demetrius II, and Antiochus VI, until 143/142. Of the usurpers of the Seleucid throne, only Tryphon affixed dates on coins according to his regnal years. Although the Seleucid capital struck no later dated silver coins, it continued to issue dated bronzes into the early second reign of Antiochus IX, until 110/109. There is no discernible reason why Antioch should have discontinued dated silver after only 12 years while continuing to affix dates to its bronze coinage for the next three decades, but Seleucid coinage is filled with examples of such experiments and reversals. Ever different from their western counterparts, mints of the Seleucid east struck no regular dated coinage at all until the very end of Seleucid rule, when Seleucia on the Tigris produced a few dated bronzes for Antiochus VII.

Quasi-municipal Coinages

In a departure from the practice of issuing royal bronzes with principally dynastic types, the Antioch mint began in 169/168 to strike bronze coinage for Antiochus IV with the king's radiate portrait and the name of the city on the reverse. Eighteen other cities followed with their own quasi-municipal bronzes, some with local reverses but many showing a Zeus reverse for at least one denomination (fig. 13.22). The quasi-municipal coinages of the Syrian north, Cilicia, and northern Mesopotamia were discontinued after Antiochus IV's reign but experienced a brief revival under Alexander I, when Seleucia in Pieria, Apamea, Laodicea, and Cyrrhus struck quasi-municipal bronzes in single years, perhaps as a rotating privilege or the result of a visit by the king. Ever a region with its own traditions, Phoenicia's four major mints—Byblus, Berytus, Sidon, and Tyre—struck bronzes in four denominations, each of which employed reverse types of purely local significance (fig. 13.23).

p. 246 The degree to which the quasi-municipal coinages of Antiochus IV and Alexander I were inspired by royal design or local civic interests remains in question. Whatever the case, their circulation patterns, to the extent they are known, indicate that with the exception of such Tyrian bronzes, such coins did not travel far from their issuing cities. It has been suggested (Mørkholm 1966) that the sudden appearance of such coins under Antiochus IV was due to a desire by the king to revive civic life in his kingdom, but if such was the case, the policy was highly selective and was applied only to cities in the west and Mesopotamia. A brief issuance of quasi-municipal coins under Alexander I may have been an early form of *adventus* coinage, struck to honor the king and the city on the occasion of a royal visit. These coins were struck only in single years and seem to follow a northerly progression.

Fig. 13.21

Fig. 13.22

Fig. 13.23

Marks of Value

Under Antiochus IV, three mints—Nisibis, Seleucia on the Tigris, and, probably, Samaria in Coele Syria—affixed obverse marks to their bronze coins (AX, BX, or ΔX; fig. 13.24). Value marks (BX and ΔX only) appeared again on a late set of bronze coins of Timarchus struck at his capital, Ecbatana; on a single issue of Demetrius I of Seleucia on the Tigris (AX); and on a single bronze issue of Alexander I, also struck at Ecbatana (ΔX). Scholarship is united that the marks represent abbreviations for *chalkous, dichalkon,* and *tetrachalkon*, but there is no consensus on the reasons for their appearance, although revaluations of bronze may have been the primary purpose.

Attempts at Standardization

Throughout the third and into the second centuries, many cities of the Seleucid kingdom had issued bronze currencies for local use that often differed in size, weight, and perhaps value from those of other localities. Against this tradition, the Seleucid state made occasional attempts to establish coinages for broad regional use, or bronze denominations that were approximately similar, city to city, evidently with the purpose of creating a unified state- or region-wide currency system. Most such attempts lasted only briefly, were not followed consistently, and were not picked up or reflected in coin production in other areas such as the east. If their purpose was to establish a currency system that could be broadly used throughout the kingdom, they were not applied consistently and seem not to have been particularly successful.

There is no clear pattern with regard to the number of bronze denominations a mint might issue. Antioch, for example, struck no less than four, or perhaps five, denominations under Seleucus IV, reducing these to two under Antiochus IV p. 247 ↳ (three if one includes the quasi-municipal issues), increasing these to four under Demetrius I, and continuing with a variety of emissions to the reign of Antiochus XI, under whom but one denomination was struck. With the exception of the quasi-municipal coinage inaugurated under Antiochus IV, Ptolemaïs (Ake) held to a single denomination from the reign of Antiochus III through that of Demetrius I, increased this to three denominations under Alexander I and later Antiochus VI, and issued two denominations under Antiochus VII and during the joint reign of Cleopatra Thea and Antiochus VIII, when the mint's bronze coinage appears to have been calibrated to its counterpart at Antioch. The same varying pattern of denominational issuances appears at other mints, including those in the east.

Fig. 13.24

Changes in Mint Operations

From an early point in its history the Seleucid state, while concentrating major coinage production at a limited number of major mints, had nevertheless allowed many mint facilities to operate, often intermittently, as the kingdom expanded. Following the tumultuous reign of Antiochus III, however, several factors combined to enlarge the number of mints operating in some areas while reducing it in others. In the west and north, formerly active mint cities north of the Taurus Mountains, now no longer under Seleucid authority, stopped producing Seleucid money entirely. In the Syrian interior, Damascus issued tetradrachms for Seleucus IV, as it had for Antiochus III, before closing and transferring operations to Ptolemaïs (Ake), which dramatically, if only briefly, expanded its silver coinage under Antiochus IV. In Phoenicia, new silver mints were opened at Berytus, Sidon, and Tyre under Alexander I, with Sidon and Tyre continuing to issue tetradrachms and some smaller silver into the reigns of Antiochus VII (Sidon) and the second reign of Demetrius II (Tyre). Very possibly to help finance his expeditions against the Parthians, Antiochus VII inaugurated new emissions at a number of still-unidentified facilities in northern Syria (*SC2*: 372–375); he also reopened the mint at Damascus in the second year of his reign (S.E. 175 = 138/137 B.C.), which continued to function into the reign of Antiochus XII, finally closing in 84/83 B.C.

In the east, small mints in northern Media, including one established by Antiochus III perhaps at Rhagae, were opened to issue tetradrachms and drachms that circulated broadly across the Iranian plateau, but these closed after only a few decades of operation as the Seleucids were forced to cede territory to the Parthians. Similarly, a number of mints in southern Babylonia (one perhaps at Charax) and on or near the Persian Gulf issued silver for Antiochus IV, but most of these ceased production after only a few years of operation.

From the third decade of the second century, the story is much the same: occasional expansion of mint production, much of it probably related to an occasional need for official payments, against the background of a general retrenchment of the Seleucid state against the territorial pressures it faced from the Romans in the north and Parthians in the east, as well as from fragmentation from within. As the first century began, the p. 248 ↳ Seleucid kingdom had been reduced territorially to a few major cities in Cilicia and northern and central Syria. Under Seleucus VI, six mints issued silver coinage (Seleucia on the Calycadnus, Elaeusa [Sebaste], Tarsus, Antioch, and two other still-unidentified facilities), five under Demetrius III. Of these, only Antioch and Damascus issued silver money in any volume, and by the end of the dynasty the kingdom had collapsed to only one mint, Antioch, which produced a limited number of tetradrachms for Antiochus XIII (64 B.C.) before Seleucid authority was extinguished.

New Foreign Currencies

By the last decade of the third century, spread-flan Alexander tetradrachms from Asia Minor, including in particular issues struck in Pamphylia, began to replace the lifetime and early posthumous Alexander tetradrachms that had until then made up the largest proportion of coins circulating in the Seleucid kingdom. Within a few decades the Pamphylian tetradrachms, along with issues of Side, flooded the currency markets of Syria and Cilicia, and would remain an important component of currencies circulation in the Seleucid west until the last third of the second century, when they disappeared. Such non-Seleucid money may have been meant for state purposes, but it seems more likely that it was principally intended as payments for mercantile exports or services. Certain coins of Side and Alexanders of Pamphylian manufacture with anchor countermarks entered circulation in the 170s; their appearance may have been related to the financing of Antiochus IV′s invasion of Egypt in 175, although episodes of anchor countermarking may also have occurred under Demetrius I (162–150 B.C.)

About 160 B.C., Athens′s New Style tetradrachms began to circulate in Seleucid Syria, and shortly after the midpoint of the century, tetradrachms of Myrina and Cyme, with wreathed reverses followed by similarly wreathed coins of other Asia Minor cities, began to enter Seleucid currency markers. The reason for the appearance of such wreathed coins in Seleucid Syria only is not entirely clear, but may have been related to the interest of the Attalids in supporting the military campaigns of Alexander I against Demetrius I, which began around 152 B.C.

The Deterioration and Debasement of Seleucid Money

From the beginning of the Seleucid dynasty until 173/172, the weight of Attic standard tetradrachms issued at Antioch and other western mints had remained constant at a median of about 17.0 g. In that year, the weight of tetradrachms struck at p. 249 ↳ Antioch and Ptolemaïs (Ake) was allowed to fall to a value of between 16.6 and 16.7 g, almost certainly to reduce the silver requirement of 15,000 talents imposed by the Romans in the Treaty of Apamea (189) and to help finance the military spending needs of Antiochus IV.

The Antioch mint held to the new standard for more than three decades, but a second reduction seems to have taken place when Alexander II was put on the Seleucid throne by Ptolemy VIII in 128, or perhaps slightly later.

This time, however, the Attic standard did not stabilize, and within a few years—beginning, apparently, during the first adult reign of Antiochus VIII (at Antioch, 124–121 B.C.)—commenced a decline, marked by episodic weight reductions, that extended into and past the middle of the first century. By the time of the last Seleucid ruler, Antiochus XIII (64 B.C.), the modal weight of Antioch's coins was in the range of 15.30–15.39 g, far below that of the previous century. The coinages of Seleucid Phoenicia, too, suffered a reduction of their own Phoenician standard. Measured over the relatively short period of their issue (c. 151–125 B.C.), the tetradrachms of Tyre show a small but statistically significant decline of weight, from a median of 14.10 g under Alexander I to 13.95 g during the second reign of Demetrius II.

In addition to the reduction of weight, there appears to have been a significant drop in the purity of Seleucid silver coins issued at Antioch, and probably also at other mints. The evidence from a variety of sources, while still very limited, indicates that the decline began about 120 B.C., or a bit earlier, and continued, although it appears to have been somewhat inconsistent, especially in the first century. Available data suggest that by 60 B.C., the silver content of Antioch's tetradrachms had declined to about 60%.

The reasons underlying the decline in weight and the debasement of Seleucid silver are not hard to understand. As Seleucid rulers found themselves increasingly pressed for funds to finance military and other requirements of the court, they began to look to money circulating in their own territories as a way to add to their treasuries. The kingdom's financial authorities may have thought that small weight adjustments would be paralleled by correlative adjustments in the money of other states that then circulated into Syria. Such seems to have occurred in the case of the first weight reduction of Antiochus IV. But the second major reduction of around 128, combined with the ongoing reduction of silver fineness, appears to have had profound, and eventually catastrophic, consequences.

The most important of these was that the Seleucid monetary system slowly closed. As newly struck lower value coins were produced, earlier Seleucid and foreign coins of higher intrinsic worth—including all Alexanders, Athens's New Style issues, and wreathed-reverse tetradrachms—disappeared entirely from the Seleucid money stream, melted for bullion and other purposes, or recoined (as occurred several times, massively under Philip I, c. 95/94–c.76/75 B.C.). In the place of circulating tetradrachms that had been only partly Seleucid, silver money circulating in Seleucid territory became increasingly, and finally overwhelmingly, made up of Seleucid coins of recent issue. By the last decades of the second century, north Syrian tetradrachms produced on the reduced
p. 250 Attic standard circulated almost exclusively ↳ within the confines of the Seleucid kingdom; the Kessab Hoard of around 110 B.C. (*IGCH* 1568) is the last recorded appearance of "foreign" money in a hoard of overwhelmingly Seleucid content. Whatever economic benefits had accrued to the state and the Seleucid financial class from the open monetary system that had been allowed to prevail over the previous two centuries were now lost.

Late second- and early first-century hoards from the area show little mixing of currencies and indicate that the financial systems of the several states in the region operated independently. Each state appears to have believed that it could achieve commercial or financial advantage by promoting and using its own money within a closed economic system that allowed free currency exchange with only a relatively small number of partners, while making exchanges with states whose currencies were based on other weight standards much more difficult. For its part, the Seleucid kingdom, which at the end of the second century consisted of only a handful of cities in Cilicia and the Syrian north, adhered to the declining standard of Antioch without reference to other currency systems of the area. The ultimate effect was to reduce the usefulness of Seleucid money for payments outside the kingdom and to help accelerate the decline of Seleucid financial power, weakened already by the incessant wars that plagued the later kingdom.

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Key to Illustrations

Fig. 13.1. Seleucus I, Babylon, tetradrachm: SC1 87.4b (AH photo file).

Fig. 13.2. Seleucus I, Babylon, lion stater: SC1 88.8b (AH photo file).

Fig. 13.3. Antiochus VII, Seleucia on the Tigris, tetradrachm: Paris.

Fig. 13.4. Antiochus III, Antioch, octodrachm: 74.

Fig. 13.5. Cleopatra Thea and Antiochus VIII, Ptolemaïs-Ake, octadrachm: CSE2, 716.

Fig. 13.6. Alexander I, Berytus, tetradrachm: CSE 706.

Fig. 13.7. Seleucus I, Pergamum, tetradrachm: CSE 633.

Fig. 13.8. Antiochus III, Uncertain Mint 60, AE: CSE 889.

Fig. 13.9. Antiochus VII, Seleucia on the Calycadnus, tetradrachm: CSE 530.

Fig. 13.10. Seleucus I, Susa, tetradrachm: CSE 1025.

Fig. 13.11. Antiochus III, Seleucia on the Tigris, tetradrachm: New York, ANS.

Fig. 13.12. Alexander II, Antioch, AE: Jerusalem, SNGSpaer 2308.

p. 251 Fig. 13.13. ↳ Seleucus II, Seleucia on the Tigris, AE: CSE2, 253.

Fig. 13.14. Antiochus II, Ecbatana, tetradrachm: CSE2, 161.

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Fig. 13.16. Demetrius III, Seleucia in Pieria, AE: CSE2, 797.

Fig. 13.17. Timarchus, Seleucia on the Tigris, tetradrachm: CSE 990.

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Fig. 13.22. Antiochus IV, Nisibis, AE: Jerusalem, SNGSpaer 1156.

Fig. 13.23. Antiochus IV, Berytus, AE: CSE 694.

Fig. 13.24. Antiochus IV, Seleucia on the Tigris, AE: CSE 982.

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